

The year 1975 and 1976 saw the release of the *Atari Pong* and the *Coleco Telestar* respectively. Both were single-game systems, only letting you play their respective version of the game *Pong*. (Incidentally, Atari was sued by Magnavox, who claimed that their *Pong* game was too similar to Magnavox's *Tennis*. Atari eventually had to pay Magnavox.

The next big step in consoles came in 1976 with the Fairchild Channel F a.k.a. the Fairchild VES (video entertainment system). This was the very first console to feature a cartridge-based game system, which meant a person could play multiple games on a single console. Thus, not only could one play the two in-built games, but with the cartridge came the ability to play four other games.

In hindsight, the Fairchild was also revolutionary simply because its design closely resembles a modern console. It came with two controllers with rotating buttons that could be pressed, and also featured a pause mode, which was unheard of at the time.

By 1977, the RCA realised their mistake and decided to enter the console market themselves. The result was the RCA Studio II. They were made to rue their decision not to adopt Baer's technology, because the Studio II bombed at the market. It was an inferior piece of technology (it only gave black-and-white graphics) and was promoted poorly. All in all, this was a console that was soon forgotten.

In retrospect, 1977 was destined to become a part of gaming history. It was in this year that Atari launched their legendary Atari 2600 console. Code-named 'Stella,' it was radically different in its design because unlike other logic-based consoles, its core was a complete CPU. It also used a custom-built sound and display chip called the TIA (Television Interface Adaptor). Launched at a price of \$199 (Rs 1,800 back then), it was direct competition for the Fairchild. Even Atari added a VCS (Video Computer System) suffix to the console, as compared to Fairchild's VES. Not to be outdone, Fairchild promptly renamed their console the Channel F. Neither